

Demo day and personal playbook

Week 10, Lecture 2 · Landing the Offer: SWE Job Search for Senior CS Students

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- How to critique your own recorded mock loop and find the single highest-leverage fix
- What the data shows worked across formal and side-door channels
- The five components of a personal hiring playbook
- The negotiation reminder: the moves that apply at every offer
- What the steady-state interview habit looks like after week 10

Part 1: loop review and peer critique

Why you record the loop

- Your self-perception of an interview and the interviewer's perception differ significantly
- Watching the recording closes that gap in a way that self-reflection alone cannot
- You catch things you never noticed: long silences, the exact moment you stopped narrating, the solution path you started and abandoned without saying why
- The recording is not evidence of how bad you are. It is evidence of exactly what to fix.

How to watch your own mock loop

Watch each round twice. First pass: watch without pausing. Do not take notes. Notice your overall emotional reaction.

Second pass: watch with a stopwatch and note:

- The exact minute you stopped narrating your reasoning
- Any moment when the interviewer asked a clarifying question you should have anticipated
- Any moment you restarted a solution without explaining why
- How much time remained when you declared the solution done

These timestamps are your data.

Finding the highest-leverage fix

Most mock loops have one fix that is worth more than all the others combined. It is usually not a knowledge gap. It is almost always a communication gap.

Common highest-leverage fixes:

- Resume narrating at minute 15 of a 45-minute problem
- Skipping requirements clarification in the design round because it felt obvious
- Delivering a behavioral story that had a situation and a task but no result
- Finishing a solution correctly but forgetting to walk through a test case

One specific fix practiced consistently outperforms ten vague improvements.

Part 2: what worked across channels

Formal channel: what the data shows

Formal-channel applications that reached a phone screen had one of three things in common:

1. A referral from someone inside the company (strongest predictor)
2. A tailored message that named a specific team, product, or problem
3. A resume that matched the job description's exact technology vocabulary

Generic applications to companies with no relationship and no keyword match had the lowest conversion rate to phone screen of any channel.

Side-door channel: what actually converted

The side-door moves that most reliably produced conversions:

- An open-source PR merged into a repo the company maintains: the engineer who reviewed the PR is a warm contact
- A specific cold email with a real artifact attached: not a request for advice, but a demonstration of work
- A referral activated through a second-degree contact who was willing to make an introduction

Graham (2023): "Curiosity is the key to all four steps in doing great work." The side-door moves that worked were all driven by genuine curiosity about a specific company or problem.

The pattern that repeats

In every successful search this kind of approach shares a structure:

1. The candidate knew something specific about the company that most applicants did not
2. The candidate used that knowledge to do something specific: a PR, a message, an artifact
3. The specific thing created a reason for a person at the company to respond

The formal channel confirms the candidacy. The side door creates the introduction. Both are necessary; neither alone is sufficient for the highest-quality conversations.

Part 3: the personal hiring playbook

Why you need a playbook

You will not do this search exactly once. If the first offer is not right, you will search again. If you change roles in two years, you will search again. A personal hiring playbook means the next search starts at week 10, not week 1.

Graham (2023): writing a page a day compounds over years. The playbook is that kind of compounding: every search adds evidence about what works for you specifically.

The five components

A complete personal hiring playbook has five parts:

1. **Target list with reasoning:** which companies, which tiers, which side-door surface each one has
2. **Story bank:** 12-15 STAR stories indexed by leadership signal, updated after each search
3. **Design preparation:** the two or three system design problems you can run confidently and the one tradeoff you know well
4. **Sprint cadence:** the daily template from week 10, annotated with what you adjusted and why
5. **What worked and what to repeat:** one paragraph per channel, honest about the conversion rate you actually saw

Building the playbook this week

You already have most of the material:

- Target-company list from week 1, updated all term
- Story bank from HW 5, refined through mock practice
- System design write-up from HW 4
- Application sprint log from the capstone
- Mock loop critique from the capstone

The playbook is not a new document. It is an organized summary of what you built. Spend 30 minutes this week assembling it into one place.

Part 4: the negotiation reminder

The negotiation rule that never expires

McKenzie (2012): "Negotiating never makes worthwhile offers worse. This means you need a commitment strategy: you always, as a matter of policy, negotiate all offers."

The policy is the key word. You decide in advance that you will always negotiate. You do not decide in the moment, under offer pressure, whether this particular offer is worth negotiating. The decision is already made.

What to say when you receive a verbal offer

Do not accept or decline on the phone. Say:

"Thank you. I am very excited about this. Can you send me the details in writing? I want to review everything carefully before I respond."

Then, after you have the written offer and at least 24 hours to think:

"I want this move to be a strong step forward for me in compensation. Is there flexibility on [base / signing / equity]?"

McKenzie (2012): "You can trivially pick up \$5,000 in salary negotiations just by sucking less."

Trading across dimensions

If the recruiter says there is no flexibility on base salary:

- Ask about signing bonus
- Ask about equity refreshes
- Ask about accelerated vesting
- Ask about the review timeline for the first raise

Each dimension is a separate ask. A no on one dimension does not close the others. Qureshi (2016): “What they’re doing is praying with bated breath that you’ll sign the offer.”

Part 5: what comes next

The steady-state interview habit

After week 10, you do not stop. You shift from sprint mode to steady-state:

- Two LeetCode mediums per week, narrated aloud (NeetCode roadmap, continue from where you are)
- One system design sketch per month: design something new, time it, check the tradeoffs
- Story bank: add one new story every time you do something worth remembering

This is 2-3 hours per week. It keeps the skills warm so the next sprint starts at week 10 quality, not week 1 quality.

When to stop applying

Stop sending new applications when you have one of these:

1. A signed offer from a company you are genuinely excited about
2. Three active on-site processes in progress (more than three creates scheduling conflicts that hurt all of them)
3. A clear signal that your current profile is not passing a specific stage, and you need to address that gap before continuing

Do not stop because the search feels hard. Hard is normal. Stop when you have a good reason.

The post-offer transition

Between signing and your start date:

- Read the onboarding documentation the company sends. Ask questions before day one.
- Set up your development environment if the company allows it
- Talk to at least one engineer who joined in the last year. Ask what they wish they had known.
- Decide on one technical skill you will strengthen in the gap. Work on it consistently, not in a sprint.

The start date is not the finish line. It is the start of the next compounding period.

Curiosity is the key to all four steps in doing great work: it will choose the field for you, get you to the frontier, cause you to notice the gaps in it, and drive you to explore them.

<footer>Paul Graham, "How to Do Great Work," 2023</footer>

Take-aways

1. Watch your mock loop twice: once for the overall picture, once with a stopwatch to find the exact moment things broke. The highest-leverage fix is almost always a communication gap, not a knowledge gap.
2. The formal and side-door channels work together. The side door creates the introduction; the formal channel confirms the candidacy.
3. A personal hiring playbook is a summary of what you built this term, organized so the next search starts at week 10 quality.
4. Negotiate every offer, as a policy. Decide in advance; do not decide under pressure.
5. After week 10, shift to steady-state: two problems per week, one design per month, one new story every time you do something worth remembering.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 10 reading covers the full two-track playbook, the sprint template, and the post-offer transition in one place
- **Section (this week):** Mock interview marathon, four back-to-back rounds, debrief
- **Capstone (due this week):** Application sprint log, mock loop critique, one unconventional move documented
- **After the course:** Run the steady-state habit. When you get the offer, negotiate. Then update the playbook.